

Has watching sport become an exercise in data management?

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I took a quiz at the end of the World Cup (I am a sucker for quizzes, and have been since school). It says something about something (perhaps football, perhaps quizzes, perhaps Messi, perhaps me, most of all me) that I got only six right out of 20 questions.

I had watched every match that insomnia permitted. I had recorded the ones I missed to be watched later. I knew which coach chewed gum with philosophical intensity, and which goalkeeper adjusted his socks before penalties.

I will never forget a commentator, in the final, speaking of “Yamine Lamal” every time the ball was played to the Spanish player and wondering a) why he couldn’t read the correct name on his TV monitor b) why his colleagues didn’t correct him c) if this was racism or merely lack of professionalism and d) would he call Harry Kane “Karry Hane”.

I analysed the answers I had got wrong and realised that many of them were about percentages and distances and involved decimal points. Half-time entertainment (“Crap” according to Wayne Rooney, and we can’t argue with that) may be seen as the attempt to Americanise a global game. Art here is secondary to arithmetic.

Football, once a game played with feet and imagination, has become a sport enjoyed in an Excel spreadsheet. If it can’t be explained in numbers, it does not exist. I exaggerate, but you get the idea.

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possession percentages, expected goals, progressive carries, defensive actions, heat maps that resemble abstract art. All very good for coaches and those who prefer to pin everything down for things to make sense. But somewhere, a child is growing up believing that football was invented to produce graphics.

Memory doesn’t work like statistics, though. The best part of sport, the magic, is not what you can pin down but what you can’t. Messi’s sudden acceleration, Haaland’s instinct for being in the right place at the right time.

There was a time when fans remembered moments. Maradona utilising the hand of god for personal reasons, Zidane using his head but not in the way football allowed, Iniesta’s gentle goal. They were memories because they carried emotion, not because someone converted them into multiple-choice questions.

Now we are expected to remember passing accuracy in the middle third. The hydration break is another statistic that is new to football. How much water was drunk, how many millions did television make, how far did a player have to run to get to the sideline...

So perhaps neither Messi nor I am to blame. Nor, strictly speaking, football itself. We watch for the poetry of the unexpected, for the music of the build-up, the release with the goal. Or the silence — heavy with both hope and despair — before the penalty, underlined by the baby sleeping peacefully in a parent’s arms. Sport is kinder to feelings than facts, but none of these appeared in the quiz.